

Making Friends (or Trying To)

Swedes have a reputation for being cold and hard to befriend. It's not really true — they just have different social rules. Once you understand them, everything clicks. This chapter is your guide to cracking the Swedish social code.

Introducing Yourself

Keep it simple and genuine. Swedes value authenticity over big personalities. A calm, honest introduction goes much further than trying to impress. No need for a firm handshake speech — just be yourself.

Jag heter...

/yah HEH-ter/

My name is... — Literally 'I am called.' The standard introduction.

Vad heter du?

/vah HEH-ter doo/

What's your name?

Trevligt att träffas!

/TREHV-lit aht TREF-as/

Nice to meet you! — Say this and you're already ahead of most tourists.

Jag kommer från...

/yah KOM-er frohn/

I come from... — Fill in your country or city.

Jag bor i...

/yah boor ee/

I live in...

Jag är här på semester

/yah air hair poh seh-MES-ter/

I'm here on vacation.

Jag är här för att jobba

/yah air hair fur aht YOB-ah/

I'm here for work.

Jag lär mig svenska!

/yah lair mey SVEN-ska/

I'm learning Swedish! — This is your CHEAT CODE. Say it and watch Swedes light up.

CULTURE TIP

Saying 'Jag lär mig svenska' is basically a social superpower. Swedes genuinely LOVE when foreigners try to learn their language. Most will immediately start helping you practice, teaching you words, and being way more open than they would otherwise. It breaks the ice instantly.

Talking About Yourself

Once you've introduced yourself, people will want to know more. Here's how to talk about your life, work, and interests.

Vad gör du?

/vah yur doo/

What do you do? — Asking about work is common but not the first question like in some cultures.

Jag jobbar som...

/yah YOB-ar som/

I work as... — Fill in your profession.

Jag studerar...

/yah stoo-DEH-rar/

I'm studying...

Jag gillar att...

/yah YIL-ar aht/

I like to... — Talk about your hobbies.

...resa / laga mat / träna / läsa

/REH-sah / LAH-gah maht / TREH-nah / LEH-sah/

...travel / cook / work out / read — Common hobby words.

Jag älskar Sverige!

/yah EL-skar SVEHR-yeh/

I love Sweden! — Always well received.

Hur länge har du bott här?

/hoor LENG-eh har doo boht hair/

How long have you lived here? — Great question to keep conversation going.

Small Talk (Yes, It Exists in Sweden)

Swedes don't do small talk with strangers the way many cultures do. Chatting with the person next to you on the bus? Unthinkable. But in the right context — at work, at a party, through activities, at a bar — they open up. The trick is knowing the safe topics.

Fint väder idag!

/fint VEH-der ee-DAHG/

Nice weather today! — Weather is THE universal Swedish small talk topic. Always safe.

Vilken fin dag!

/VIL-ken feen dahg/

What a nice day! — Especially powerful if the sun is actually out.

Har du några planer i helgen?

/har doo NOH-grah PLAH-ner ee HEL-gen/

Do you have any plans for the weekend? — Common Friday conversation.

Vad har du gjort idag?

/vah har doo yort ee-DAHG/

What have you done today?

Har du sett någon bra serie?

/har doo seht NOH-gon brah SEH-ree-eh/

Have you seen any good shows? — Swedes love discussing TV series.

Har du varit i...?

/har doo VAH-rit ee/

Have you been to...? — Travel is a safe and loved topic.

Vad gillar du att göra på fritiden?

/vah YIL-ar doo aht YUH-rah poh FREE-tee-den/

What do you like to do in your free time?

CULTURE TIP

Safe small talk topics in Sweden: weather (always), travel, food, TV/movies, sports, nature, and hobbies. Topics to be careful with early on: politics, religion, salary, and anything too personal. Swedes open up gradually — don't rush it. And never, ever ask a Swede how much they earn. It's considered extremely rude.

The Fika Invitation — Your Secret Weapon

Fika isn't just coffee. It's the number one way friendships form in Sweden. Inviting someone for fika is low-pressure, casual, and socially acceptable in almost any situation. It's how Swedes say 'let's hang out' without it feeling like a big deal.

Ska vi ta en fika?

/skah vee tah en FEE-kah/

Shall we grab a fika? — THE friendship opener. Use it.

Vill du fika?

/vill doo FEE-kah/

Want to fika? — Even more casual.

Vi kan fika någon gång?

/vee kan FEE-kah nohn gong/

We could fika sometime? — A softer suggestion, no pressure.

Jag bjuder!

/yah BYOO-der/

My treat! / I'm buying! — A nice gesture that goes a long way.

Det var jättetrevligt att prata med dig

/deh var YEH-teh-TREHV-lit aht PRAH-tah med dey/

It was really nice talking to you — A warm goodbye that opens the door for next time.

CULTURE TIP

If a Swede says 'Vi ses!' (See you!) or 'Vi hörs!' (We'll be in touch!) when saying goodbye, it usually means they genuinely want to see you again. Swedes don't say things they don't mean just to be polite. If they say it, they mean it.

Unwritten Social Rules Nobody Tells You

Sweden has invisible social rules that can confuse outsiders. None of these are meant to be rude — they're just deeply ingrained cultural norms. Understanding them saves you a lot of

confusion.

Lagom

/LAH-gom/

Just the right amount — not too much, not too little. THE core Swedish value. Don't be too loud, too flashy, too anything.

Jantelagen

/YAN-teh-LAH-gen/

The Law of Jante — An unwritten social code: don't think you're better than anyone else. Don't brag, don't show off.

Lagom är bäst

/LAH-gom air best/

Just enough is best — The lagom philosophy in one sentence.

Hemmafest

/HEM-ah-fest/

House party — Where most real Swedish socializing happens. Getting invited to one = you're in.

Förfest

/FUR-fest/

Pre-party — Swedes ALWAYS drink at home before going out. It's cheaper and more social.

Fredagsmys

/FREH-dahgs-myhs/

Friday coziness — The tradition of staying in on Friday with snacks, candy, and a movie. Sacred.

CULTURE TIP

The Swedish concept of personal space is real. On the bus, Swedes will stand rather than sit next to a stranger. In a waiting room, they'll leave empty seats between them. At a bus stop, they spread out evenly. This isn't antisocial — it's showing respect for personal space. Don't take it personally, and don't break the pattern.

How to Actually Make Swedish Friends

Now that you know the phrases, here's the real strategy for building friendships in Sweden. It works differently than most countries, but once you understand the system, it's not hard.

Finns det några aktiviteter jag kan gå med i?

/fins deh NOH-grah ak-ti-vi-TEH-ter yah kan goh med ee/

Are there any activities I can join? — Joining clubs/groups is THE way to make friends.

Jag vill gärna vara med!

/yah vill YAIR-nah VAH-rah med/

I'd love to join! — Say yes to everything at first.

Kan jag få ditt nummer?

/kan yah foh dit NOOM-er/

Can I get your number? — Not weird in a friendship context.

Vi kanske kan hänga nån gång?

/vee KAN-sheh kan HENG-ah nohn gong/

Maybe we could hang out sometime?

Tack för en jättetrevlig kväll!

/tahk fur en YEH-teh-TREHV-lig kvell/

Thanks for a really nice evening! — Always say this after a gathering.

CULTURE TIP

The #1 way to make Swedish friends: join an activity. Sports clubs, language exchanges (språkcafé), hobby groups, volunteer organizations, university clubs (nations in Lund/Uppsala). Swedes make friends through shared activities, not random conversations. This is how their social life is structured. The friendship happens naturally through repeated meetups in the same group.

CULTURE TIP

Don't take Swedish social distance personally. If a Swede seems reserved at first, it's not that they don't like you — they just need time. Swedish friendships are slow to form but incredibly deep and loyal once established. A Swedish friend is a friend for life. Be patient, keep showing up, and the walls will come down.

Listen to This Chapter

Scan the QR code to hear every phrase pronounced naturally. No robot voices — just real Swedish.

Next up: Chapter 07 — Help! Emergency Swedish

Phrases you hope you'll never need — but absolutely must know.